assured India is, the more expressive it will be. Only then can it overcome the image of being a poor cousin mired in its colonial history.

In this endeavour, India is uniquely positioned to bridge modernity and tradition. It will be more impactful by embracing its heritage, not by diminishing it. A combination of cultural beliefs and modernizing agenda helps address many current dilemmas. Its historical characteristics are a source of strength once they are approached with confidence. For example, the appreciation of pluralism is as much a derivative of long-standing social practices as of a constitutional mandate. Similarly, stronger nationalism at home coexists traditionally with enthusiastic internationalism abroad. Rising India wants to engage the world more, not less. India matters when it is more authentically India.

Given its growing political stature and economic abilities, India has to credibly address the expectations that the world has of it. And this has to begin in its immediate neighbourhood. Those who are physically and historically close to it will naturally turn to India, especially during moments of difficulties. These could be natural disasters or man-made situations, political and economic. The challenges arise, however, when expectations of India are selectively articulated. Neighbours would naturally like it to modulate its presence as per their convenience.

From the Indian perspective, it is not always easy to get the balance right. Doing too much looks intrusive; showing reticence can be taken as indifference, if not weakness. Or losing out to a competitive power. The politics of every partner is a significant variable and context often drives calculations.

The optimal Indian strategy is, therefore, to rise above the day-to-day developments and create structural linkages. For this to happen, a combination of non-reciprocal, generous and patient policies have to come together. They must connect societies at a fundamental level, facilitating infrastructure development, socio-economic initiatives and political comfort. Those ingredients of connectivity, commerce and contacts are the core of India’s Neighbourhood First approach. It was equally evident in the manner in which India stepped forward to support Sri Lanka during its economic crisis. In the final analysis, regionalism can only be built if key players are prepared to go the extra mile. And India matters because it alone has that ability in the Subcontinent.